Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Malachi

Malachi 1:1

This is the burden of the word (literally An Oracle: The message) of the LORD to Israel: This introduction shows that the book of Malachi is an important message from God. It identifies the author and audience but not the date or reason. The word oracle gives Malachi's message authority and urgency. His audience was expected to listen and respond.

Malachi 1:2

loved: The relationship between the Lord and Israel involves covenant implications. This love can mean God's choice or election of Israel as his people. Malachi's message shows that other aspects of God's unconditional covenant love for Israel, like his patient mercy (see Malachi 3:6, 17), are still active. See also Romans 9:13.

Malachi 1:2–5

Malachi's sermons use a literary form called disputation (a structured argument). This form sounds like a courtroom scene and gives the message the tone of a trial. In the first disputation, the prophet states the central truth that God loves Israel (Malachi 1:2).

After this, the prophet challenges the people and responds to their objections. He develops this main claim through five additional messages that follow.

Malachi 1:3

- hated (the opposite of loved in Malachi 1:2): Love and hate are opposite words in Old Testament legal and prophetic texts (see Deuteronomy 7:9–10; Amos 5:15). They often describe the separation caused by a broken covenant. Here, God says he rejected Esau and his descendants, the Edomites. Esau had despised and rejected a covenant relationship with the Lord (see Genesis 25:34; 26:34–35).
- Esau was the ancestor of the Edomite nation. His inheritance, the territory of Edom, was on the southeastern edge of the Dead Sea. The mention of Jacob and Esau reminds us of the twin brothers' rivalry (Genesis 25:23–26).

Malachi 1:4

- the LORD of Hosts (Hebrew Yahweh tseba'oth): This name for God is important in Old Testament prophetic writings. Hosts are the angelic forces under God's command. This phrase emphasizes God's power, which cannot be defeated.
- the Land of Wickedness: Esau was selfish and showed disrespect for the Lord's covenant symbols (see Genesis 25:34). The nation of Edom came to represent the pride of a self-centered life (see Jeremiah 49:16). The Edomites also allied with Babylon in destroying Jerusalem (see Psalm 137:7–9; Obadiah 1:10, 12).

Malachi 1:6

who despise My name: God's name refers to his reputation and character. It describes who God is and how he is known by his people (compare Ezekiel 36:19–24). The Judeans were showing how little they thought of God by giving him worthless offerings.

Malachi 1:6–2.9

Malachi's second message confirms the Lord as God and father of Israel. God alone deserves true worship.

The first part (Malachi 1:6–14) shows how the Israelites dishonored God despite his fatherly care and great power.

The second part (Malachi 2:1–9) warns the priests of Judah against sacrificing sick and defective animals and criticizes them for not teaching God's instructions (2:6–8).

Malachi 1:7

defiled food on my table: Ceremonial uncleanness or contamination made an object or person unfit for worship ceremonies to the Lord. In this case, defilement happened by ignoring the laws about acceptable animal sacrifices (Leviticus 22:17–25; Deuteronomy 15:21).

Malachi 1:8

- The governor was Persia's appointed overseer of the province of Judah. The comparison between My altar (Malachi 1:7) and your governor (1:8) shows the Levitical priests' mixed loyalties.
- asks the LORD of Hosts: This phrase is called the messenger formula in prophetic speech and means that God supports the prophet's message.

Malachi 1:12

Dishonor was not a single event. It had become a normal pattern of life. The priests, who were responsible for guarding Israel's covenant relationship with the Lord, repeatedly dishonored him. They did this by bringing impure sacrifices to his temple.

Malachi 1:14

cursed: To "bind with a curse" meant to bring misfortune as punishment for a serious crime against the community (see Deuteronomy 27:15–26; Jeremiah 48:10). Malachi spoke for the Lord, so the curse was a declaration of doom.

Malachi 2:2

- take it to hear: This was a matter of the will (a deliberate choice), not of feelings or emotions.
- curse: Malachi referred to the complete destruction promised for those who broke God's covenant (see Deuteronomy 28:20).

Malachi 2:4

My covenant with Levi: If the Levites dedicated themselves to serving God and gave up their own glory, God would grant them life and peace (Malachi 2:5; compare Numbers 8:5–26; 25:12–13). Their special responsibility was to teach God's instructions (Malachi 2:7).

Malachi 2:7

- The priests had been trusted with God's sacred teaching, as given in the law of Moses. As teachers, they were responsible for guarding God's covenant (his binding promises) with Israel (Deuteronomy 33:9–10).
- messenger (Hebrew mal'ak): This word may intentionally echo the name Malachi (Hebrew mal'aki, meaning "my messenger"). In the Old Testament, this title usually describes a prophet. Here, Malachi applies it to priests, because they were responsible for explaining and applying God's word to the people.

Malachi 2:9

shown partiality (literally lifted up the face): The expression also appears in Malachi 1:8 ("pleased with you"). The priests should have applied the law with kindness and fairness, but they did not. It was unreasonable for the priests to think that God would favor them when they had shown partiality in performing their duties.

Malachi 2:10

- Do we not all have one Father? Did not one God create us? (or by one God): These divine titles highlight the Lord's uniqueness as Creator and his role as Israel's Father. One God reflects the Shema, Israel's statement of belief in one God (Deuteronomy 6:4–5).
- break faith: The main idea of this third message is that divorce is a betrayal.
- covenant of our fathers?: The prophet refers to the covenant made at Mount Sinai, reminding the people that the law of Moses required responsibility to both God and each other.

Malachi 2:10–16

Malachi's third message shows that the failure to keep the covenant spread from the priests to all the people. They did not keep their promises to the Lord or to their fellow citizens when they married foreign women. They also broke their promises to their wives when they divorced them. The prophet now addresses the people as fellow members of the community. This marks a clear change in tone. He moves from sharp accusation to an inclusive appeal (Malachi 2:8–9; 10).

Malachi 2:11

Judah has broken faith; an abomination has been committed in Israel and in Jerusalem: Men were divorcing their wives to marry non-Israelite women for economic gain. These marriages allowed Jewish men to join existing merchant groups and trade networks when they returned from Babylonia. Malachi compares this unfaithfulness to idol worship.

In Israelite history, marrying foreign women often led to worshiping foreign gods. Loyalty was essential in Israel's agreements, both with God and in marriage. Divorce disrespects the unity of the marriage agreement (Malachi 2:15; see Genesis 2:24).

Malachi 2:12

cut off: This phrase means to wipe out or destroy those who do evil. It does not refer to social exclusion or removal from religious worship. Instead, it describes complete judgment.

Malachi 2:14

- In the Greek Old Testament, wife is called koinōnos, meaning "joint partner." The Hebrew word for a seam or joint in construction (for example, Exodus 26:6–11) implies a lasting bond.
- covenant: Marriage is a serious promise, with God as a witness (see Proverbs 2:17).

Malachi 2:16

- hate: God dislikes a broken promise (see Malachi 1:3; Hosea 9:15). This is fitting because God's relationship with people is based on faithfulness, and he expected the same from Israel (Exodus 34:6; Deuteronomy 7:9).
- To divorce (literally send away) means to force a marriage partner to leave. Malachi wanted to ad-

dress the misuse of divorce laws (see Deuteronomy 24:1–4).
- covers his garment with violence: Cruelty involves acts of violence or wrongdoing. Divorce is a harsh and cruel social wrong. Divorcing one's wife is a betrayal of her and the marriage promise. It breaks hearts, destroys relationships, harms family integrity, damages children's well-being, and endangers the future.

Malachi 2:17

Malachi's audience had displeased and frustrated God by doubting his fairness.

Malachi 2:17–3.5

Malachi's fourth message addresses the difference between God's justice and human justice (Malachi 2:17). This section sounds like a courtroom charge against Judah. It presents God's formal accusation. Malachi condemns religious behavior that follows rules but lacks sincere devotion (see Malachi 3:14). This kind of worship goes against God's justice. The prophet calls the people to honesty and to real concern for others in their community.

Malachi 3:1

- My messenger (Hebrew mal'aki): This is a play on Malachi's name. The messenger could be an angel or a human acting as a divine courier. Jesus identified John the Baptist by referring to this passage (see Matthew 11:10; Mark 1:2; Luke 7:27).
- Malachi's audience likely saw the messenger of the covenant as a divine being (compare Exodus 23:20–23). The Christian church views Jesus Christ as the messenger of the new covenant.

Malachi 3:2

- refiner's fire: The people's wickedness must be removed through divine testing and punishment (Isaiah 1:25; Jeremiah 6:29; Ezekiel 22:22).
- launderer's soap: An alkaline detergent was made from plants (see Jeremiah 2:22). The blazing fire and strong soap represent the testing and cleansing needed to restore Israel's faithfulness to its covenant with the Lord.

Malachi 3:5

- The phrase swift witness suggests a legal case where God acts as both the prosecutor and the main witness against Judah after the exile in Babylon.
- Sorcerers used witchcraft, black magic, or fortune-telling for personal gain.
- On the coming day of God's judgment, sinful Judeans would either be purified (Malachi 3:3) or destroyed (4:1–2).

Malachi 3:6–12

Malachi's fifth message repeats the first message (Malachi 1:2–5) by emphasizing God's faithfulness to his promises. He urges Israel to be equally faithful in worship, especially by giving their tithes and offerings. If Malachi is like a courtroom scene, the fifth message is the judge's decision. The main message is repentance. God desires honest and sincere worship from his people, of which tithing is a symbol.

Malachi 3:7

turn away: In a covenant relationship, this phrase expresses a change in loyalty by Israel or God. It usually means repentance, a complete turn back to God or a full shift toward the Lord. The command is urgent and requires an immediate response. The accusation of fake worship builds on similar charges in the second argument (see Malachi 1:6–14). God's promise to open the windows of heaven (Malachi 3:10) shows his power as a great King (see 1:14).

Malachi 3:8–9

- Malachi urges Judah to renew their practice of giving to the Lord.
- Tithes, which are a tenth of the land's produce, were required offerings (see Deuteronomy 12:6, 11, 17). Offerings were extra gifts or contributions to the Lord or his sanctuary. These included:
- produce,
- material goods (like construction materials or garments), or
- personal valuables (such as gold, silver, or precious stones).
- Judah's recent troubles came from God's curse (see Deuteronomy 28:20, 27). Malachi urgently called the community to repent, return to the Lord, and follow the covenant's requirements.

Malachi 3:10

Test Me in this: God invites his people to test him. This invitation gives the restored community a chance to see that God is faithful to his covenant promises (the commitments God made to his people).

Malachi 3:12

all the nations will call you blessed: Large harvests would once again show the world the Lord's favor toward Israel.

Malachi 3:13

Your words against Me have been harsh: The people accused God of favoring wrongdoers and questioned his fairness (see Malachi 2:17). However, the Lord values justice (Psalms 9:16; 37:28).

Malachi 3:13–4.3

Malachi's final message contains two distinct but related speeches. The first emphasizes serving the Lord (Malachi 3:13–18). The second compares the fate of the wicked and the righteous (Malachi 4:1–3)

Each speech ends with the messenger formula (see study note on Malachi 1:8). The prophet revisits themes from the fourth message (Malachi 3:1–5), emphasizing God's desire for honesty and faithfulness in worship, especially with the coming judgment on the day of the Lord.

If Malachi is like a courtroom scene, this last argument is the sentencing. Although wickedness seems to win over righteousness and God seems slow to judge sin in the community, the coming day of the Lord will prove God's justice. The wicked will be separated from the righteous by the fire of God's judgment.

Malachi 3:14

- What have we gained: People believed that doing good deeds would lead to material blessings (Deuteronomy 28).
- walking mournfully: People thought that showing sadness or wearing funeral clothes showed true repentance, as if these actions were righteous by themselves (see Matthew 6:1–18).

Malachi 3:15

Calling the arrogant blessed went against God's justice, because it treated pride and wrongdoing as good (see Malachi 3:13).

Malachi 3:16

- A scroll of remembrance was a written record of names and events connected to those people. This practice was common in the Persian world. The text does not say how many people were written in the scroll.
- those who feared the LORD: These people were loyal to the Lord as God, followed God's commands, and acted righteously in conduct and worship.

Malachi 3:16–18

Here, the prophet acts as a recorder. He reports how the people reacted to his final message and how God responded to the conversation among those who feared the Lord. God listened to what they said (see Malachi 3:16). However, there is no sign that Malachi's message led to real change in most of the people.

Malachi 3:17

treasured possession: Israel held a special place as God's people. They belonged to him as his own possession.

Malachi 4:1–3

This message moves away from debate and directly warns people that repentance is the only proper response to the Lord's message because God's judgment is unavoidable.

Malachi 4:2

- The title sun of righteousness might come from the winged sun disk common in ancient Near Eastern art. It could refer to the Messiah (God's chosen one) or symbolize a new era of righteousness when God will remove the curse of sin. Israel's spiritual healing would rely on God cleansing the people and forgiving their sins (see Jeremiah 33:6–8; compare Jeremiah 8:14–15). This healing would follow a collective confession of sin and a return to God (Malachi 3:7; compare Jeremiah 14:19–20).
- in its wings: Outstretched wings symbolize God's protection and rescue (see Exodus 19:4; Deuteronomy 32:10–11; Psalm 17:8; 18:10).

Malachi 4:4

The first postscript (a short message added at the end) calls Judah to obey the law of Moses. Israel's identity began with the exodus and was shaped by the covenant made at Mount Sinai through Moses (see Deuteronomy 34:10–12).

Malachi 4:4–6

The book ends with a closing section that points to Moses and Elijah. These two figures are models of faithfulness to the Lord. Moses represents the Law, and Elijah represents the Prophets (see Matthew 17:1–4). They are held up as examples for Malachi's audience to follow.

In ancient Hebrew practice, these two appeals may have functioned as added closing messages for the scroll that contained the 12 Minor Prophets (the shorter prophetic books). If this is the case, the first closing message (Malachi 4:4) links the scroll to the Law of Moses. The second closing message (Malachi 4:5–6) connects the Minor Prophets to the Major Prophets (the longer books of Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel).

Malachi 4:5–6

- The second closing message warns that God's judgment of the wicked is coming. It also promises rescue and restoration for those who live in a right way.
- Elijah is a prime example of a prophet who preached repentance, supported by signs and wonders (see Luke 1:17; James 5:17–18). Elijah was a forerunner of the day of the Lord (see Malachi 3:1). The New Testament identifies John the Baptist as the prophet who prepared the way for Jesus the Messiah (see Matthew 11:11–15; Luke 1:17).

Malachi 4:6

- he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children: Two key themes in Malachi and the Old Testament prophets are turning hearts and reconciliation. In the Old Testament, turn means repentance and a complete change of loyalties. Turning toward God results in reconciliation between generations (see 2 Corinthians 5:18–20).
- strike the land with a curse: The word curse means total destruction (see Deuteronomy 7:26; 1 Samuel 15:18; Zechariah 14:11). The people of Israel who ignored God's prophet would face complete destruction, like the Canaanites who came before them (for example, Joshua 6:17).